

LUKASZ KOWALSKI

HORSE RIDING

Galloping to Glory

India's equestrian trailblazer **Anush Agarwalla** *rides towards Olympic dreams in the artful sport of dressage*

In September last year, India scripted history as it won its first-ever gold in dressage, an equestrian event that is as much a performing art full of balletic finesse as it is a technical sport. An integral part of the four-member squad was Anush Agarwalla, who also claimed an individual bronze at the competition. Already the only Indian to have competed at the World Dressage Championships, Agarwalla recently scripted more history having earned the country its first-ever spot in the event at the Olympics. It's still not confirmed if he will be headed to Paris come July, but the 24-year-old rider from Kolkata fancies his chances. "I feel that I will go. My results talk, you don't have to prove anything else," says Agarwalla, world-ranked #82. "The most I can do is work hard on myself and my training and perform better."

Horse riding came to Agarwalla more as a hobby initially. Always fond of animals (in addition to four horses at his training base in Paderborn, Germany, he has six Shih Tzus back home), as a child he'd go to the Tollygunge Club for riding lessons. By 11, he was spending his weekends in Delhi to further hone his skills. But picking dressage as his preferred discipline, he says, was a gradual process and he was inspired by it when he saw the event at the 2012 London Games. At 17, he decided to give horse riding as a career a real shot and headed to Germany, a country with both a rich tradition and Olympic medal haul in dressage. "Whatever I do, I want to be the best at it. I was so far away from the level I wanted to be," he says. "I knew it'd be difficult [adapting to Germany], but I knew this is what I wanted to do." Agarwalla credits his Olympic gold medallist coach Hubertus Schmidt for moulding him into a fine rider.

Being a practitioner of dressage, which has elements like a canter, passage, piaffe, pirouette and half pass, and not, say, a showier discipline like jumping, means that Agarwalla still has friends and family members who don't follow what he does. "If people think you aren't doing anything and it looks easy, you can be really proud," says Agarwalla. Dressage, he notes, requires "you to be in harmony with the horse. It takes a long time to learn and master the technique". In Paderborn, Agarwalla builds that bond by spending time caring for, feeding and bathing horses as well as taking them for walks in the forest. "I can look and know if something is wrong with them," he says.

In Paris, Agarwalla along with the gelding Sir Caramello hopes to impress the judges with a routine set to A.R. Rahman's Oscar-winning track 'Jai Ho'. Whatever the outcome, the young rider relishes the role of promoting the lesser-known sport and hopes that his (eventual) Olympic participation motivates more to take it up. Says Agarwalla, "If 20 to 30 years down the line, India has its first team in dressage at the Olympics, it would be a huge thing." Given that age is not a deterrent in dressage, with riders well into their 40s and 50s competing and even winning, the young Agarwalla is a hopeful and happy trotter. ■

–Suhani Singh